

How formal

The words people use depend on the situation they're in and the person they're talking to. In informal situations, people tend to use colloquial words, but when writing to someone they don't know, or someone in authority, they use formal vocabulary.

Hey, man. This homework sucks.
I just don't get it.

A text message to a friend can include slang, such as "Hey, man" and "sucks."

Dear Mrs. Jones,

Jake experienced some difficulties in completing last night's homework. Although he tried very hard, he could not understand the exercise. He may need some extra help so that he can finish the work.

Yours truly,
Sheila Jessop

A letter to a teacher should be written in formal language.

Word play

Writers also choose words to entertain readers. By using particular combinations of words, they can create humor and sound patterns. There are three main types of word play: puns, alliteration, and assonance.

Puns

A pun is a play on words. It exploits the multiple meanings of a word, or similar sounding words, to create humor.

Once a **pun** a time...

Alliteration

Alliteration is the effect created when words next to or close to each other begin with the same letter or sound. It is often used in newspaper headlines.

Thomas Turner tripped
over the table.

Assonance

Assonance is the effect created by the repetition of vowel sounds. It is often used in poetry.

Is it true you like blue?

Getting technical

Jargon is the term for words or phrases that are only used and understood by members of a particular group or profession. For example, doctors, lawyers, and sports professionals use certain terms to communicate quickly and effectively. However, it's best to avoid using jargon outside of these circles, since it can be meaningless to other people.

Get me his vitals.

Doctors use this term to refer to patients' vital statistics, such as their pulse, body temperature, and breathing rate.

